prime minister in India started out wielding even greater clout than in other parliamentary democracies. In conduct of foreign policy, Nehru concentrated authority in the prime minister's position, which continues to be the focal point of India's international engagement to this day.

Almost all Indian prime ministers have sought to leave their mark in the arena of foreign policy. Some of them were powerful enough to craft and implement the policies they wanted; others had to learn how to take the system along with them. Even prime ministers lacking in knowledge of bureaucratic functions quickly mastered the art in order to push for their initiatives. Nehru and his early successors conveyed their decisions through the various ministries while maintaining relatively smaller staff directly working for the prime minister. Over the years, the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) has emerged as a bureaucratic machine in its own right that has helped cement the prime minister's centrality.

In addition to the PMO, several other key institutions and offices are also engaged in Indian foreign policy. These include: the Ministry of External Affairs (external affairs minister, foreign secretary, Indian foreign service and diplomatic missions), the recently created National Security Council (national security adviser, Strategic Policy Group and National Security Advisory Board), the parliament (standing and consultative committees), and the Cabinet Committee on Security. Several ministries, especially the Ministry of Defence, the Ministry of Home Affairs, the Ministry of Finance, and the Ministry of Commerce also weigh in on matters that relate to their portfolios. India's military and intelligence services, political parties, media and think tanks have, in varying degrees, influenced India's positions on international affairs at different times in India's recent history. The input of professional civil servants and specialists outside the formal bureaucracy, however, does not change the fact that the prime minister remains the final decision maker.